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WEAKNESSES

- Frequent switchovers have eroded Nitish's political capital
- For the first time in the BJP's company, Nitish is contesting fewer seats than the saffron party in this Lok Sabha election
- Nitish's image—of someone who relinquished power after his party's poor performance in the 2014 LS poll to the one who has switched sides to continue as the CM—has taken a beating
- The prohibition policy, once lauded by women, may prove electorally counterproductive, as the implementation gaps have spawned a big bootlegging business
- Constant attacks on the RJD's 1990-2005 rule may now see diminishing returns, especially among young voters who have no memory of those times

meetings, wherein he questioned political opponents (read Lalu Prasad) for "producing too many children", his aggression is now more subdued. Though he still questions the family politics of the RJD, which has fielded two daughters of Lalu, he desists from personal attacks. His close aides describe this shift as a mark of his regained confidence.

But Bihar's "dark ages" remains a favourite stick for Nitish to beat the RJD with. At his rallies, the CM never fails to remind everyone, especially the youth, about the 15-year reign of the RJD from 1990 to 2005. This is not without reason. Among Bihar's 76.4 million voters, a staggering 9.2 million, or roughly 1.2 per cent, fall in the 18-19 age bracket —a cohort that didn't even exist when Nitish commenced his inaugural full term in November 2005. Moreover, there are an additional 16 million voters, constituting over 21 per cent of Bihar's electorate, aged between 20 and 29 years. The eldest in this demographic would have been merely five years old when Nitish took charge at Bihar's helm, making any recollection of the Lalu-Rabri Devi administration quite unlikely for them.

A STRIKING IRONY IN NITISH'S SPEECHES IS THAT HE, CREDITED WITH BIHAR'S TRANSFORMATION, RELIES ON LALU-RABRI'S "MISRULE" TO WIN VOTES

This explains why Nitish emphasises the importance of "educating" young voters about the lawlessness that prevailed in the state before his tenure. Historically, both Nitish and the BJP have thrived by presenting themselves as a reliable alternative to Lalu's "jungle raj". Nonetheless, there is a mounting apprehension that constant reminders of this threat is yielding diminishing returns. In his public addresses, Nitish speaks about how he has created 800,000 jobs in his entire tenure, including 400,000 since 2020—a milestone for which he faces formidable competition from his former deputy Tejashwi, who also lays claim to these achievements. A striking irony in Nitish's speeches is that he, credited with Bihar's transformation, relies on his predecessor's "misrule" to win votes. Such is the reality of the state's caste-ridden politics that the CM is seen reminding more about the bad old days than making promises of '*achhe din*' in the future.

The Strong Points

A close Nitish associate points out that even in 2014, when he finished with just two Lok Sabha seats, Nitish had still secured 16 per cent of the votes. "Similarly, in the 2020 assembly polls, when Nitish's tally slipped to just 43 seats, he still garnered 15.4 per cent of the votes. This indicates that his committed voters never desert him even in the worst of times. This is his biggest strength. This is why the BJP central leadership aligned with him. The results will once again prove his relevance," he claims.

Apart from the EBCs, Nitish also commands a following among the SCs. According to last year's caste survey, SCs constitute 19.6 per cent of Bihar's population, up from 16 per cent in Census 2011. With both Chirag Paswan and Jitan Ram Manjhi as alliance partners, Nitish is expected to garner SC support as well, bolstered by his dozen or so pro-SC welfare schemes. But there are also challenges galore. The RJD-led INDIA bloc has fielded seven Kushwaha candidates, raising the possibility of the numerically significant Yadavs and Kushwahas coming together in many seats.

As the seven-seater Agusta 109 ascends, carrying Nitish for his third meeting of the day in Vaishali, the question lingers: will his fortunes rise with it? ■